

VETCERT



Exam rules

Consulting Level

Version: March 2023

Instructions to candidates

Outdoor exercises

Consulting level

The outdoor session will last 120 minutes. It will involve a mix of oral questions and exercises. Please do not confer with other candidate(s). You may use a camera to take photos of the trees to be included in your management plan, however no other electronic technology may be used. A mobile phone with a camera may be used to take photographs but it may not be used for other purposes (i.e. telephoning a friend or colleague or browsing the internet).

Exercise 1

The first exercise requires you to undertake a survey of two veteran trees [*examiner to take candidates to labelled trees*]. Please use the time allocated as part of the outdoor exam to record adequate information to be able to write a short management plan for each tree. Surveying equipment such as sounding mallet, measuring equipment, binoculars may be used for the assessment.

Later today you will have 120 minutes to prepare the management plan. You will be provided with a blank digital management plan template to complete. A computer should be used to produce this plan.

The items below are the headings under which the management plan will be marked along with the potential marks available. Any management specifications should be adequately described so that the person undertaking the work clearly understands what should be done. Photos may be used to illustrate your plan.



1. Health and vitality of the tree (20 marks)
Please ensure you explain what factors you have taken into consideration when assessing the health and vitality of the tree.
2. Structural condition (biomechanics) of the tree (20 marks)
Please ensure you explain what factors you have taken into consideration when assessing the structural condition of the tree.
3. Wildlife, historical, cultural or social values of the tree (12 marks)
You only need to write about two of these four options, but please pick the two most relevant and explain how these values apply to your tree.
4. Threats to the tree (12 marks)
Please describe the most significant threats to the tree, including their potential impact, and also including what will happen if you do nothing.
5. Management plan (24 marks)
Please provide a management plan for this tree with a timetable, work specifications and monitoring. This should include sufficient detail to allow the work to be planned, from start to finish, and ensuring that a contractor or site manager knows exactly how to undertake the work. Feel free to use photos to illustrate your specifications.
6. Management justification summary (20 marks)
Considering everything you have assessed and described above, please provide a short summary justifying why you think your management plan is the most appropriate for the tree. This summary should include both positive and negative impacts for the tree. Upon reading this summary, the tree owner should feel convinced and compelled to follow your advice.

A total of 117 marks are available for Exercise 1 (43% of the exam).

Exercise 2

The second exercise relates to the history of a specific tree and the landscape it sits within. There is no requirement to submit any written answer for this tree, however, feel free to make notes if you wish. You will be asked some questions about the history of the tree and the landscape.

Exercise 3

The third exercise relates to the risk assessment of this tree. Please inspect the tree. There is no requirement to submit any written answer for this tree, however, feel free to make notes if you wish. You will be asked some questions about your approach to risk assessment of this tree.

Generic oral questions

In addition to the above exercises, the examiner will collect each candidate in turn to ask some generic oral questions during the 120 minutes.

Exercises 2, 3 and the generic oral questions are worth 58 marks (21% of the exam).

